

Celebrating Oneself Through Walt Whitman's "Song of Myself"

ENG110: Literature for Life
Faculty Initial



Walt Whitman (1819-92) is one of the few great nineteenth-century in America

- He grew up in Brooklyn (he was four) amongst eight of his siblings
- He started working at the age of 11, and by the age of 15, he worked as a compositor (full-time).
- His occupations during his lifetime included printer, schoolteacher, reporter, and editor
- Upon publishing Leaves of Grass, Whitman was fired from his Department of the Interior job. Despite his mixed critical reception in the US, he was favorably received in England
- 1830s-1850s is a very important time for America

Read more from: <https://www.britannica.com/biography/Walt-Whitman>

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- At the age of 19, he created his weekly paper called “The Long Islander”
- Around 1840-50s he was very involved in politics
- He stayed in Washington DC for a decade and worked in various federal government and even a nurse in union hospitals

American Transcendentalism (1836-1861)

- Any individual is greater than an institution. There is no reason for a church.
- They believed that basic truths come from intuition
- Inner soul leads to truth
- Individual relationship with God were much better than church
- Nature is self-knowledge
- All nature is significant, and goodness is nature persists
- Individualism
- The mind is the greatness of mysteries and knowledge

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- Ralph Waldo Emerson's "Nature" (1836).

Notably, to J.T. Trowbridge in 1860: "I was simmering, simmering, simmering; Emerson brought me to a boil" (qtd. in Trowbridge 166). Trowbridge adds: "He freely admitted he could never have written his poems if he had not first 'come to himself,' and that Emerson helped him to 'find himself'" (166).

Whitman attempts to decipher the nature of society by using his own experiences and emotions. Whitman is highly individualistic.

- Non-violent civil obedience (Henry David Thoreau)
- Transcendentalists believe that the divine spirit resides within all of us, they embrace intuition rather than rationality

Key Points to Study

- What is the significance of the poem's title?
- How many imagery can you identify?
- Why does Whitman present the idea of nature as an intangible part of the self?
- What is the “self” for an individual; in relation to others; in relation with the universe and nature